



fitness standards of India's dominant pace trio, Bumrah, Shami, and Ishant Sharma, which managed a consistent run under Virat Kohli's tenure despite facing their respective share of injury woes.

Basu, who looked after their training, revealed that a flexible programme, one which is tailored to specific needs, helped in bringing the best out of Indian players.

"We did not have anything fancy; we just took it case by case. Each person was different. Bumrah was one type, Ishant Sharma was another, Bhuvneshwar was one type. Every player functions differently from the inside. Our plans were customised. We had a culture where I could advise freely. If someone had to be rested from training, if someone had to be given a break from gym work, it was done with a combined mindset. We all had a discussion on a

daily basis. The injury rehab process was also similarly simple. Patrick Farhart was also there; he was a great help. We used to take every case day by day," Basu says.

In a set-up as well established as the CoE, it is hard to imagine a drop in standard. The recent spate of injuries has brought questions to the CoE's door, but Leipus might be right in granting the facility a little more leeway. "It's about the use of fitness as a term. It's a very generic term; it encompasses so many different variables, and it's easy to point the finger at poor fitness? A broken finger is not poor fitness. Getting hit on the toe is not poor fitness. Managing a chronic knee or a chronic back in an important player is not fitness; it's just injury management," he says.

In the past, the team management has erred by wanting

**Managing load:** Pat Cummins in full flight, his absence from four of five 2025-26 Ashes Tests underscoring the value of putting long-term fitness ahead of immediate demands.

GETTY IMAGES

certain players' rehab expedited, with Harshit being a case in point. While it is fair to expect accountability from the CoE, given the sheer scale of investment, it cannot be solely held responsible. Yes, it is one cog in the set-up, but the team is run by the management and the selectors too. The CoE trains and fixes the players, but it's the other two that often dictate the pace of their recovery.

There are things the CoE needs to set in order, finding a head of sports science being one of them. But this demands more calibration than a crisis intervention.